

How the Government is Promoting FOSS Adoption in India

This article examines some of the initiatives by the Indian government to encourage the wider acceptance of FOSS. These include developing new access-friendly technologies, organising FOSS workshops and training, providing certificates for online training courses, and conducting valuable R&D activities.



Bharat Operating System Solutions (BOSS)

BOSS is a localised multilingual operating system based on GNU/Linux. It supports as many as 18 different languages from all corners of India. Its sturdy architecture complies with the strict e-governance requirements. This OS, certified by the Linux Foundation, also offers another variant aimed at educational purposes. It can be downloaded and distributed for free. This new solution offers a highly affordable computing platform. It is playing a vital role in improving governance while helping schools to impart education in a better way.

The countrywide BOSS support centres have been actively conducting workshops and training sessions to enhance its mass appeal across a wide section of people. These centres are also involved in free distribution of the CD/DVD of the software to acquire a wider population of users. Complete support — right from operational training to installation and maintenance — is being provided by the centres.

National Resource Centre for Free and Open Source Software (NRCFOSS)

The National Resource Centre for Free and Open Source Software (NRCFOSS) has been set up to assist the Indian FOSS community in designing and developing open source software. The centre has played a key role in various ambitious projects including developing

Free and open source software, abbreviated as FOSS, helps people and organisations benefit from digital technologies without a huge investment or binding clauses and restrictions. As opposed to proprietary software, FOSS products are available for free, don't charge for licences and offer much wider compatibility that allows them to integrate with different technologies and hardware. They have therefore become very popular in India over the past few years.

Role of government organisations in promoting FOSS

Numerous IT enterprises and communities are actively furthering the wave of FOSS adoption by producing FOSS based products,

providing infrastructure support for it, and organising or sponsoring community events and meetups (online and offline).

The important question is: Is the Indian government promoting and encouraging FOSS adoption at a wider level in the country? What are the different exercises needed to achieve this objective? Are any national-level IT organisations involved in promoting FOSS — and in what ways? What have they achieved till now? These are some of the questions this article will attempt to answer.

A few large government organisations in India are actively involved in widening the awareness about FOSS in the country. These will also be discussed in this article.